

Trained Judgement, Uneven Ground



Inaugural India edition in the Design & Foresight series. Companion to the global cycle 'Trained Judgement in the Age of Automated Foresight' (May 2026).

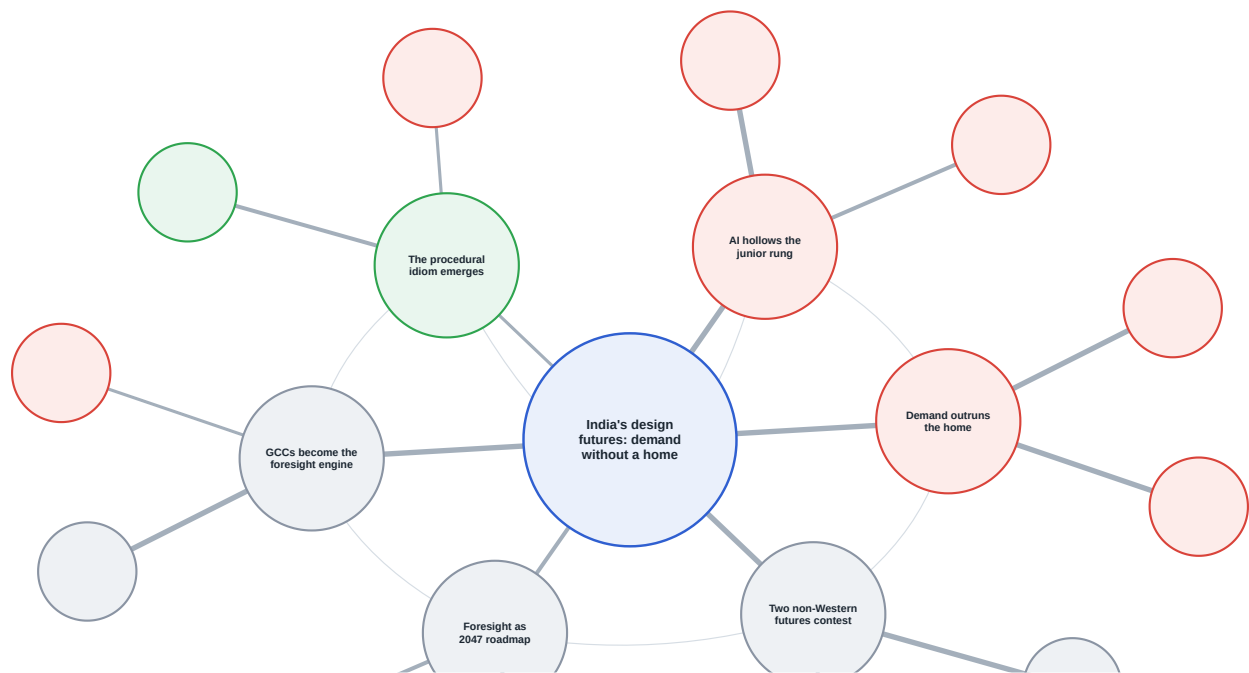
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○ risk ○ opportunity ○ mixed/neutral impact × likelihood: — high — med — low



What you'll learn

1. Why AI is automating the junior design and UX rung that has been India's traditional entry into the field, exactly as the demographic wave peaks.
2. Why demand for design futures, a state writing 2047 visions, 2,117 GCCs running global innovation, and a world hungry for plural futures, is outrunning India's domestic institutions.
3. Why the contest over what "Indian futures" means, a state-branded Bharatiya project versus an academic pluriversal one, will decide whether the field is a soft-power instrument or a critical discipline.
4. Why India's most distinctive futures practice may be procedural and plural, a thing global AI foresight tools trained on Western imagery cannot reproduce, if it is codified rather than left tacit.

Key takeaways

1. AI is compressing the junior design rung, 78,000 tech jobs lost, entry roles cut 20-25%, 93% of designers on AI tools, just as the demographic wave peaks and a million creative graduates enter yearly.
2. Demand outruns the home: no futures-studies centre, a 2007-era design policy, and marquee futures IP housed abroad, while 2,117 GCCs run the innovation in-house.
3. Two non-Western futures pull the field apart: a state Bharatiya project (IKS mandate, orange economy) against an academic pluriversal one (jugaad, plural knowledge).
4. Government mainstreamed foresight as 2047 roadmap-writing, while India's live speculative work, the Kochi climate courtrooms, sits outside the institutions.

Executive Synthesis

Why this matters now

This is the inaugural India edition in the Design & Foresight series, so it sets a baseline rather than grading a prior cycle. It applies the global cycle's finding, that trained human judgement gains value as foresight automates, to the specific case of India. The organising observation: India is being handed the demand for design futures at the very moment AI is hollowing the junior rung that feeds the field, while the domestic institutions that would let it own the discipline stay thin.

Four shifts this cycle establishes as the baseline, and the pattern that names them:

- **The on-ramp is automating away.** AI is compressing the junior design and UX rung, India's traditional entry into the field, as the demographic wave peaks and roughly a million creative graduates enter yearly.
- **Demand outruns the home.** A state writing 2047 visions, 2,117 GCCs running global innovation, and a world hungry for plural futures all want a design-futures capability India has not built at home.
- **The field is pulled between two non-Western futures.** A state Bharatiya project and an academic pluriversal one contest what "Indian futures" means, and whichever captures the institutions defines the discipline.
- **Foresight arrived as roadmap-writing, not speculative practice.** The state mainstreamed 2047 visioning as target-setting, while India's live speculative work happens outside the institutions.
- **Name the pattern: uneven ground.** The demand, the talent and the distinctive idiom are all present; the trained-judgement pipeline and the domestic home are not, so India risks staffing the world's futures while its own goes uncoded.

This cycle names the variable that will decide the future of design futures in India: not whether demand exists, it plainly does, but whether India builds the trained-judgement pipeline and a domestic home fast enough to own the field it is already exporting talent into. Four developments carry the pattern.

First, the on-ramp into the field is automating away. NITI Aayog's own AI-jobs roadmap records [78,000 tech jobs lost to AI by mid-2025](#) and warns 60% of formal-sector jobs are automation-susceptible by 2030; entry-level roles are being [cut 20-25%](#), and [93% of Indian designers already use AI tools](#). The junior production role that has been India's route into design is compressing exactly as the [demographic dividend peaks around 2030](#).

Second, demand for design futures is outrunning the domestic home to house it. A state writing 2047 visions, a design-services market [set to nearly double to \\$2.7bn by 2030](#), and [2,117 global capability centres](#) running innovation in-house all want the capability, yet the [National Design Policy is still the 2007-era policy](#), no university futures-studies centre surfaced, and India's most-cited futures method, [Pupul Bisht's Kaavad-derived foresight](#), is housed abroad.

Third, the field is being pulled between two non-Western futures. A state Bharatiya project, a [UGC mandate for Indian Knowledge Systems](#) and a [Create in India orange economy](#), sits against an academic pluriversal one that argues even [decolonising design still over-centres design](#) and proposes jugaad as an autonomous practice. Whichever frame captures the institutions decides whether Indian design futures is a soft-power growth instrument or a critical discipline.

Fourth, foresight arrived in India as roadmap-writing. Government has mainstreamed long-horizon visioning, [Viksit Bharat 2047](#) and [Telangana Rising 2047](#), but as aspirational target-setting rather than the scenario or critical practice [futures literacy](#) describes, while India's live speculative work, the [speculative climate courtrooms](#) at the Kochi-Muziris Biennale, happens outside the institutions.

*The demand, the talent and the distinctive idiom are all present.
The pipeline and the domestic home are not.*

The historical rhyme worth holding is India's own IT-services ascent: India built the world's back office and became indispensable to it, yet largely captured the lower-margin delivery layer rather than the product and the intellectual property. The risk this cycle names is the same shape for design futures, that India staffs the world's foresight and innovation, through GCCs and a diaspora of celebrated practitioners, without building the institutions that would let it own the field.

Where this analysis could be wrong

The most consequential assumption is that the absence of a domestic home is a binding constraint rather than a temporary lag a fast-moving system will close on its own. If the GCCs' in-house innovation work, the diaspora studios, and the state's 2047 machinery are themselves the emerging institutions, functioning homes for design futures in a new form, then the "no home" framing mistakes a reconfiguration for a gap, and India is building the field through corporate and state channels rather than universities. The falsifiable tests: whether a credible India-based futures-studies centre or a revised National Design Policy and India Design Council appear within two cycles; whether GCCs begin publishing and teaching foresight method rather than only applying it; and whether the AI compression of junior roles is offset by new higher-judgement roles at comparable scale. Signals to watch: a national design-policy relaunch; a university or GCC futures programme with method output; and net design-and-foresight employment through 2027.

What this cycle establishes as the baseline

1. **The hollowed on-ramp, baseline set.** AI is compressing the junior design rung as the demographic wave peaks; the open variable is whether higher-judgement roles emerge at comparable scale.
2. **The domestic white space, baseline set.** Demand outruns domestic supply; the open variable is whether a national design-policy relaunch or a futures-studies home appears.
3. **Two non-Western futures, baseline set.** The Bharatiya and pluriversal projects both claim non-Western ground; the open variable is which captures curriculum and institutions.
4. **The 2047 foresight machine, baseline set.** Foresight is mainstreamed as roadmap-writing; the open variable is whether critical and speculative practice gains a foothold.
5. **Inaugural scan delta.** The scan ran 26 sources across four themes, roughly three-quarters at Tier 1 or 2, drawing on government, UN bodies, universities and industry. As a structural topic, much of the evidence is foundational (reports, studies, policies) and flagged as structural anchors; subsequent cycles will grade what materially changes against this baseline.

Each is developed below, with a decision posture, in the four Strategic Implications.

Baseline ledger: the dated commitments this cycle sets for the next

As the inaugural India edition, this cycle has no prior obligations to resolve. Instead it fixes the dated watch-items the next cycle will grade, each with a source and a horizon to check.

Watch-item	Type	What to check, and by when
National Design Policy relaunch	DECISIVE	Whether the 2007 policy and India Design Council are revised. No 2025-26 relaunch surfaced; check by the next cycle.
A university futures-studies home	DECISIVE	Whether an India-based futures-studies centre or design-foresight degree appears, versus the current elective-only status.
IKS in design curricula	MILESTONE	How the UGC 5%-credit IKS mandate lands in design and foresight teaching specifically.
GCC foresight output	MILESTONE	Whether GCCs begin publishing or teaching foresight method, not only applying it in-house.
Net design-and-foresight employment	IN TRAIN	Whether higher-judgement roles offset the 20-25% entry-level compression through 2027.

Audience Snapshots

Four functional lenses on the same intelligence base. Each card names the shift and the single question this cycle puts to that function's leadership.

DESIGN EDUCATION & UNIVERSITIES

Are you building the futures-studies home, or exporting the talent that needs one?

The shift: no India-based university futures-studies centre surfaced and speculative design remains an [elective rather than a discipline](#), even as the [UGC IKS mandate](#) reshapes curriculum, roughly a million creative graduates enter yearly, and AI [compresses the entry roles](#) that fed the field.

The question to brief: should we stand up a design-foresight programme or centre now, one that produces method and not only graduates, rather than teach speculative design as an elective?

GOVERNMENT & FORESIGHT POLICY

Is your foresight machinery writing 2047 targets, or building futures capability?

The shift: [Viksit Bharat 2047](#) and [Telangana Rising 2047](#) have mainstreamed long-horizon visioning as target-setting, but the [National Design Policy is still the 2007 policy](#) and [futures literacy](#) as a capability has no home.

The question to brief: should we pair the 2047 roadmap machinery with a home for critical and speculative futures, and relaunch the design policy and council?

GCC & CORPORATE INNOVATION

Is your GCC applying foresight, or building the capability India can own?

The shift: 2,117 GCCs now run R&D, product P&L and GenAI in-house for global parents, the design-services market is heading to \$2.7bn by 2030, and the studio and agency model is eroding as innovation moves onshore but stays foreign-owned.

The question to brief: should we invest in foresight-method capability and talent development in-country, not only apply it, so the capability compounds locally rather than accruing to the parent?

DESIGN STUDIOS & PRACTITIONERS

Is the procedural, plural idiom your advantage, if you codify it before AI homogenises it?

The shift: 93% of Indian designers now use AI tools, junior roles are compressing, and India's most distinctive practice is procedural, not object-based: speculative climate courtrooms, jugaad systems and craft-derived methods that global AI tools trained on Western imagery are structurally blind to.

The question to brief: should we codify and teach the procedural, plural methods that are India's distinctive contribution, before global AI foresight tools homogenise the field around a Western canon?

Themes

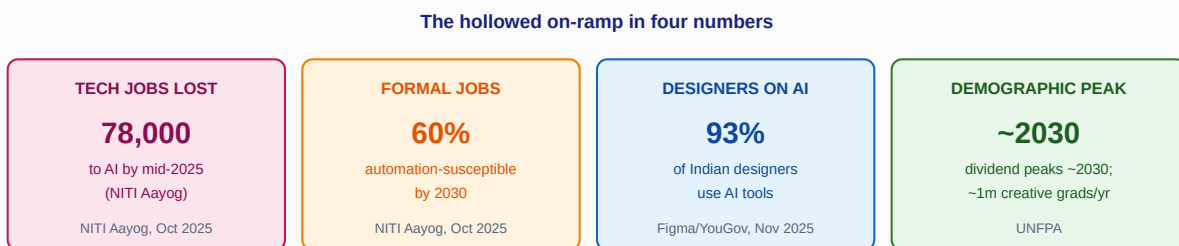
*The cycle's signals are organised into four themes, ranked by impact on near-term decisions. **Immediate:** changes H2 2026 / H1 2027 capital, siting or offtake decisions. **Near-Term:** changes competitive position over the next twelve months. **Longer-Range:** a multi-year shift to track each cycle.*

1. The Hollowed On-Ramp: AI is automating the junior rung that feeds the field

IMMEDIATE

AI is automating the junior design and UX rung that has been India's traditional entry into the field, at the exact moment the demographic wave peaks. NITI Aayog records 78,000 tech jobs lost to AI by mid-2025 and warns 60% of formal jobs are automatable by 2030; entry-level roles are being cut 20-25%; and 93% of Indian designers already use AI tools. India adds roughly a million creative graduates a year into a market whose on-ramp is narrowing, so the feed of hands-on experience that produces trained judgement, the very thing the global cycle finds gains value as foresight automates, is thinning from the bottom.

The hollowed on-ramp in four numbers



The rung automates just as the wave of talent crests.

India's design-and-foresight on-ramp in four numbers. Source: NITI Aayog, Figma/YouGov, UNFPA.

- NITI Aayog's AI-jobs roadmap records 78,000 tech employees lost to AI by mid-2025 and warns ~60% of formal-sector jobs are automation-susceptible by 2030. [NITI Aayog](#) (October 2025).
- Indian IT services cut entry-level positions 20-25% to automation and AI, per EY, closing the junior on-ramp that fed design and engineering. [Rest of World](#) (9 December 2025).
- 93% of Indian designers use AI tools, the highest adoption of any surveyed market, compressing the production tasks juniors learned on. [Figma / YouGov](#) (13 November 2025).
- 86% of global creators use creative generative AI, with India cited as a top-ROI adoption market, accelerating the shift from making to directing. [Adobe](#) (28 October 2025).
- Graduate employability is 56.35% and India holds 16% of the global AI talent pool, so the constraint is judgement and readiness, not headcount. [India Skills Report 2026](#) (11 November 2025).
- India leads the world in AI talent acquisition (~33% annual hiring rate) with talent concentration up threefold since 2016, per Stanford's AI Index. [Press Information Bureau](#) (19 December 2025).
- India's working-age population surpasses 98 crore, about 65%, by 2030, when the demographic dividend peaks, so the on-ramp narrows as the talent wave crests. [Economic Survey 2025-26](#) (29

January 2026).

Counter-argument

The compression could be a repositioning rather than a loss. India leads the world in AI talent acquisition and holds 16% of the global pool, so if AI-augmented, higher-judgement design roles emerge at comparable scale, the field trades a low-margin production rung for a higher one and the demographic wave is an asset, not a liability. The falsifiable test is net design-and-foresight employment through 2027. The named actors to act on are NASSCOM and NITI Aayog as workforce planners, the design schools that own the pipeline, and the GCCs that are now the largest employers.

Weak signals to watch

- **WEAK SIGNAL** AI tools trained on Western design data may deskill Indian juniors into prompt-operators rather than judgement-builders. Would gain weight if entry roles reappear as AI-supervision jobs with no craft progression.
- **WEAK SIGNAL** The NEP's emphasis on creativity and higher-order skills could reposition the pipeline toward judgement rather than production. Would gain weight if a design school reports a curriculum shift from tool-craft to foresight and synthesis.

Decision link: Strategic Implications [1](#).

2. The Institutional White Space: demand for design futures outruns the home to house it

NEAR-TERM

Demand for design futures is outrunning the domestic institutions to house it. A design-services market heading to \$2.7bn by 2030, 2,117 global capability centres running innovation in-house, and a state writing 2047 visions all want the capability, yet the National Design Policy is still the 2007 policy, no university futures-studies centre surfaced, and India's most-cited futures intellectual property is housed abroad, Pupul Bisht's Kaavad method at the London-based School of International Futures, Superflux operating from London. India is exporting the field it has not built at home.

The white space in four numbers

The white space in four numbers



The demand is domestic; the institutions that hold it are not.

India's design-futures demand-supply gap in four numbers. Source: India Design Council, Grand View, Zinnov-nasscom.

- The National Design Policy of 2007 remains India's governing design policy and the India Design Council (2009) has had no 2025-26 relaunch, the white space at the centre of the field. [India Design Council](#) (evergreen).
- India's product-design and development-services market grows from \$1.42bn (2024) to \$2.71bn by 2030, the fastest-growing regional market in Asia-Pacific, so demand is compounding. [Grand View Research](#) (17 November 2025).
- India hosts 2,117 global capability centres across 3,728 units, employing ~2.36 million and generating \$98.4bn as of FY26, increasingly leading the AI mandate for global parents. [Nasscom-Zinnov 2026](#) (3 July 2026).
- GCCs are moving into R&D, product P&L and GenAI deployment as transformation hubs, doing the innovation and foresight work in-house for global parents. [Oliver Wyman](#) (12 November 2025).
- The Union Budget 2026-27 proposes a new National Institute of Design in the eastern region, citing a shortage of Indian designers and insufficient capacity, an official acknowledgement of the white space. [AlphaStreet](#) (2 February 2026).

- India's most globally cited foresight innovation, a Kaavad folk-storytelling method, is housed in a London-based initiative rather than an Indian university, evidence the intellectual property is being developed offshore. [OCAD University \(Pupul Bisht\)](#) (2017).

Counter-argument

The "no home" framing may mistake a reconfiguration for a gap. If the GCCs' in-house innovation, the diaspora studios and the state's 2047 machinery are themselves the emerging institutions, functioning homes for design futures in a new corporate and state form, then India is building the field through channels other than universities and the absence of a futures-studies centre matters less than it appears. The falsifiable tests are whether a credible India-based futures-studies centre or a revised National Design Policy appears within two cycles, and whether GCCs begin publishing and teaching foresight method rather than only applying it. The named actors are DPIIT and the India Design Council as policy owners, NID and the IITs as the pipeline, and the GCCs as de-facto R&D homes.

Weak signals to watch

- **WEAK SIGNAL** A national design-policy relaunch or a university futures-studies centre would flip this theme from white space to a genuine build. Would gain weight if a design school or ministry announces a design-foresight centre or degree.
- **WEAK SIGNAL** A GCC-university foresight partnership could build capability onshore rather than exporting it. Would gain weight if a GCC funds or co-runs a futures-method programme with an Indian university.

Decision link: Strategic Implications 2.

3. Two Non-Western Futures: the Bharatiya project and the pluriversal one pull the field apart

NEAR-TERM

A contest over what "Indian futures" means is pulling the field in two directions. A state Bharatiya project, a UGC mandate for Indian Knowledge Systems and a Create in India orange economy, reframes futures as economic-nationalist soft power; an academic pluriversal project argues even decolonising design over-centres design and proposes jugaad as an autonomous practice. Both claim non-Western ground, but one is governmental and growth-branded and the other critical and pluriversal, and whichever captures curriculum and institutions will decide whether Indian design futures becomes a soft-power instrument or a critical discipline.

Two non-Western futures in four numbers



Two non-Western projects, one state-branded, one critical.

India's contested non-Western futures in four numbers. Source: UGC, ORF, FICCI-EY, Springer.

- By March 2026, 16 Indian Knowledge Systems initiatives span the IITs and IIMs, turning the UGC 5%-credit mandate into a coordinated academic movement. [Organiser](#) (4 March 2026).
- India is fusing a Create in India orange economy with Make in India: ~2.5m active creators, a \$1bn creator fund, and media-and-entertainment toward Rs 3.07 trillion by 2027, reframing creativity as export power. [Social & Political Research Foundation](#) (29 December 2025).
- India's media and entertainment sector grew 9% to Rs 2.78 trillion in 2025, the growth-and-soft-power frame into which design futures is being pulled. [FICCI-EY](#) (24 March 2026).
- India's creative economy is ~\$35bn with creative exports of ~\$11bn in 2023, now a state-branded soft-power and export project set against a ~\$1.4 trillion global creative-services market. [Observer Research Foundation](#) (4 February 2026).
- Scholarship argues Indian design education stays Western-centric and that even decolonisation over-centres design, proposing jugaad as an autonomous curriculum model, the pluriversal counter-project. [Gahlot et al. \(Springer\)](#) (13 February 2025).
- A non-Western foresight method adapting India's Kaavad folk-storytelling tradition is one of the only foresight methods drawn from a non-Western tradition, the pluriversal project's exemplar.

Counter-argument

The two projects need not be rivals. A synthesis is possible in which Bharatiya knowledge systems become raw material for pluriversal, critical practice rather than a heritage-affirming curriculum, and in which the orange economy's funding resources speculative work rather than crowding it out. On that reading the "two futures" framing overstates a conflict that policy design could reconcile. The falsifiable test is whether IKS funding reaches critical and speculative work or only heritage affirmation. The named actors are the Ministry of Education, AICTE and UGC on the Bharatiya side, design academics and studios on the pluriversal side, and the funders who could bridge them.

Weak signals to watch

- **WEAK SIGNAL** If IKS becomes heritage affirmation only, the critical and pluriversal current migrates abroad, as it already has with Bisht and Superflux. Would gain weight if a leading Indian critical-design programme relocates or loses funding.
- **WEAK SIGNAL** If the orange economy's creator funding is directed at speculative and critical practice, the two projects fuse into a distinctive Indian school. Would gain weight if a state creator fund backs a speculative-futures or critical-design programme.

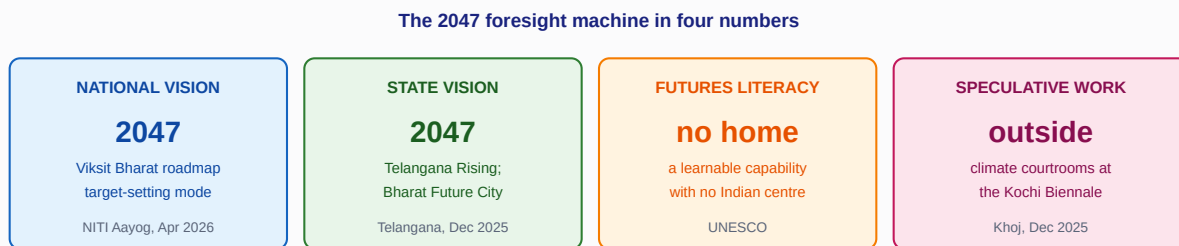
Decision link: Strategic Implications 3.

4. The 2047 Foresight Machine: the state mainstreamed foresight as roadmap-writing, not speculative practice

LONGER-RANGE

Government has mainstreamed foresight in India, but as long-horizon roadmap-writing rather than scenario or critical practice. Viksit Bharat 2047, Telangana Rising 2047 and the DRDO technology-foresight function entrench visioning as aspirational target-setting; futures literacy as a learnable capability has no home; and India's live speculative work, the climate courtrooms at the Kochi-Muziris Biennale and jugaad systems, happens outside the state machinery. The risk is that "foresight" in India comes to mean 2047 targets, while the plural, procedural practice that is its distinctive contribution stays uncoded and exposed to homogenisation by Western-trained AI tools.

The 2047 foresight machine in four numbers



Foresight arrived as targets; speculation lives outside.

India's foresight mode in four numbers. Source: NITI Aayog, Government of Telangana, UNESCO, Khoj.

- India's dominant government foresight mode is long-horizon 2047 roadmap-writing (Viksit Bharat), aspirational target-setting rather than scenario or critical-futures practice. [NITI Aayog](#) (April 2026).
- Telangana launched a Rising 2047 vision at a Bharat Future City summit, the first Indian state explicitly branding itself for global talent, extending the 2047 roadmap mode to the states. [Government of Telangana](#) (6 December 2025).
- India runs in-house technology-foresight functions through the DRDO and the Principal Scientific Adviser, focused on tech horizon-scanning rather than plural or speculative futures. [DRDO](#) (evergreen).
- UNESCO frames futures literacy as a learnable capability developed through Futures Literacy Laboratories since 2012, the discipline India has mainstreamed as roadmap-writing but not built as capability. [UNESCO](#) (evergreen).
- Speculative courtroom hearings with real judges test how environmental loss might be represented as legal evidence, a distinctly Indian, procedural futures idiom staged outside the state machinery. [Khoj International Artists' Association](#) (13 December 2025).

- The Kochi-Muziris Biennale 2025-26 hosts these speculative climate courtrooms staged toward real future litigation, design-futures-as-jurisprudence rather than gallery prototype. [ArtAsiaPacific](#) (2 March 2026).

Counter-argument

Roadmap-writing may be the appropriate foresight mode for a development state, mobilising resources at scale toward concrete targets, and critical or speculative futures can grow alongside it rather than instead of it, so the two are not zero-sum. On that reading the "machine" framing understates how much a 2047 vision can legitimise and fund experimental practice downstream. The falsifiable test is whether critical and speculative futures gain a foothold inside or beside the 2047 machinery within the horizon. The named actors are NITI Aayog and the Principal Scientific Adviser on the roadmap side, the biennales and studios on the speculative side, and UNESCO and academia as the discipline's custodians.

Weak signals to watch

- **WEAK SIGNAL** India's procedural idiom, climate courtrooms, jugaad and craft-derived methods, is a distinctive contribution global AI foresight tools trained on Western imagery cannot yet reproduce, an uncoded advantage. Would gain weight if an Indian institution codifies and teaches these procedural methods as foresight practice.
- **WEAK SIGNAL** If the 2047 machinery absorbs speculative method, India owns a plural foresight practice; if not, the practice stays tacit and exportable. Would gain weight if a government foresight unit commissions scenario or speculative work rather than target roadmaps.

Decision link: Strategic Implications 4.

Strategic Implications

Four decisions the cycle brings forward, each with an owner, a dated action and a decision posture (Decide, Prepare, Monitor). One line names who gains from each shift.

SI 1: Rebuild the on-ramp around trained judgement, not production

AI is compressing the junior production rung (78,000 tech jobs lost to AI, entry roles cut 20-25%, [93% of designers on AI tools](#)) exactly as the [demographic wave peaks](#). Shift design and foresight curriculum and early-career hiring from tool-craft to synthesis, framing and judgement now, so the pipeline produces the capability that gains value as foresight automates. If AI-augmented higher-judgement roles emerge at comparable scale on their own, the move is early rather than wrong.

Action: within this cycle, redesign at least one flagship design or foresight programme, and its entry-hiring criteria, around judgement and synthesis rather than production tool-craft.

Who gains: the design schools and GCCs that reposition first, and the cohort that acquires judgement rather than tool-operation skills.

DECIDE

Draws on Theme 1. Owner: Design school deans / NASSCOM skills leads.

SI 2: Build the domestic home before the field's talent and IP consolidate abroad

Demand outruns supply: a design-services market [heading to \\$2.7bn by 2030](#) and [2,117 GCCs](#) want the capability, but the [National Design Policy is still 2007-era](#) and the marquee IP is [housed abroad](#). Relaunch the design policy and stand up an India-based futures-studies or design-foresight centre that produces method. If GCCs and the state 2047 machinery are already the emerging homes, the centre complements them rather than duplicating.

Action: within two cycles, secure a commitment to a revised National Design Policy and a university-based design-foresight centre with a published method programme.

Who gains: India-based futures centres and the practitioners who can build IP at home rather than export it; the universities that host the discipline.

DECIDE

Draws on Theme 2. Owner: DPIIT / Ministry of Education / university leadership.

SI 3: Bridge the two non-Western futures so the field becomes a discipline, not an instrument

A state Bharatiya project (the [UGC IKS mandate](#), the [orange economy](#)) and an academic pluriversal one ([jugaad as autonomous practice](#)) are pulling the field apart. Direct IKS and creator-economy funding toward critical and speculative practice, not heritage affirmation alone, so Indian knowledge becomes raw material for a discipline rather than a soft-power instrument. If the two prove genuinely incompatible, the prepare-stage design work still surfaces the choice before it hardens.

Action: this cycle, define how IKS and orange-economy funding can resource critical and pluriversal design-futures work, and pilot one bridging programme.

Who gains: design academics and studios who can fuse Indian knowledge with critical method; students who inherit a discipline rather than a curriculum of affirmation.

PREPARE

Draws on Theme 3. Owner: Ministry of Education / AICTE / design academics.

SI 4: Codify the procedural idiom and give speculative futures a foothold beside the 2047 machinery

Government has mainstreamed foresight as [2047 roadmap-writing](#), while India's live speculative practice, the [climate courtrooms](#), jugaad and craft-derived methods, sits outside the institutions and is a thing global AI tools trained on Western imagery cannot reproduce. Monitor and prepare to codify this procedural idiom and win it a foothold beside the roadmap machinery, before homogenisation erodes the advantage. If roadmap-writing legitimises experimental practice downstream, the foothold arrives on its own.

Action: by the next cycle, document the procedural and plural methods as teachable foresight practice, and secure one government or biennial commission for speculative rather than target-based futures.

Who gains: the studios and scholars who codify India's distinctive idiom, and an India that exports method rather than only talent.

MONITOR

Draws on Theme 4. Owner: NITI Aayog / Principal Scientific Adviser / studios.

Scenario Matrix

Four operating environments for the next five to ten years, generated by crossing two axes the evidence base does not yet decide: whether India captures the value of design futures or staffs it for others, and whether it builds a domestic home or leaves the white space. The matrix is a planning tool, not a forecast; the value sits in the indicators that would tip a reader from one cell to another.

VALUE CAPTURE

Staffing the World's Futures

The worst pairing: no national design-policy relaunch and no futures-studies home, while the value accrues abroad through GCCs, diaspora studios and a Western-trained AI canon. India trains roughly a million creatives a year into other people's futures, and its own plural, procedural idiom stays tacit and uncoded.

Indicators: no policy relaunch or centre within two cycles; leading critical-design programmes relocate or lose funding; GCC foresight output stays internal to global parents.

Corporate Capture

India captures the value of design futures, but through corporate and state channels rather than universities. GCCs, the 2047 machinery and diaspora studios become the de-facto homes; the field thrives as applied innovation and soft power rather than as a taught, critical discipline.

Indicators: GCCs publish or teach foresight method; the orange economy funds practice; but no university futures centre or design-policy relaunch appears.

The Trained Exporter

India builds the domestic home, a centre, a revised policy, curriculum, but the value still accrues abroad as trained talent leaves and IP is developed offshore. A well-built export pipeline, the shape of India's IT-services ascent repeated for futures.

Indicators: a design-foresight centre or policy relaunch appears; but net talent and marquee IP flow outward; diaspora studies keep the headline method.

HOME BUILT

The Owned Discipline

The best pairing: India builds the domestic home and captures the value. A national policy relaunch, a futures-studies centre, IKS and pluriversal practice fused, and the procedural idiom codified and taught. India owns a distinctive design-futures discipline rather than staffing everyone else's.

Indicators: a national design-policy relaunch and a futures-studies centre; IKS funding reaching critical practice; the procedural idiom codified and exported as method, not only talent.

WHITE SPACE

What We Are Not Planning For

Four scenarios held out of the plan because the evidence base does not yet justify resourcing against them. Each carries the reinstatement trigger that would change that judgement.

Exclusion 1: A collapse of the demographic dividend into mass creative unemployment

The AI compression this cycle names is at the junior production rung, not the whole field, and India [leads the world in AI talent acquisition](#). We are not planning for a wholesale collapse of creative and design employment within the horizon; the near-term story is repositioning, not disappearance.

Reinstatement trigger: *net design and creative employment falling materially through 2027 without higher-judgement roles emerging to offset it.*

Exclusion 2: A wholesale rejection of the global design and foresight canon

The field is contested, not severing: global tools, methods and canons remain in use even as the [Indian Knowledge Systems](#) and pluriversal projects grow. We are not planning for a full decoupling from the global canon within the horizon.

Reinstatement trigger: *a policy mandate replacing global design and foresight curricula wholesale with IKS-only content.*

Exclusion 3: Automated foresight fully replacing trained judgement

The global cycle's finding, which this edition inherits, is that trained judgement gains value as foresight automates. We are not planning for AI foresight tools to displace the discipline itself within the horizon; the risk is deskilling the on-ramp, not eliminating the top.

Reinstatement trigger: a credible demonstration that automated foresight matches expert plural-scenario work on quality, not only speed.

Exclusion 4: A near-term national design-policy relaunch as the base case

No 2025-26 relaunch of the [2007 National Design Policy](#) or the India Design Council surfaced, and the policy persists unrevised. We are not planning around an imminent policy overhaul as the base case, while flagging it as the single most consequential watch-item.

Reinstatement trigger: a government announcement of a revised National Design Policy or a reconstituted India Design Council.

Discussion Points

1. If AI is compressing the junior design rung as the demographic wave peaks, do we rebuild the on-ramp around trained judgement now, or wait and risk a lost cohort?
2. **For educators and policymakers:** if demand for design futures outruns the institutions, do we relaunch the National Design Policy and stand up a futures-studies home this cycle, or keep exporting the talent?
3. If two non-Western futures projects, Bharatiya and pluriversal, are pulling the field apart, do we bridge them, and does Indian Knowledge Systems funding reach critical practice or only heritage affirmation?
4. If government has mainstreamed foresight as 2047 roadmap-writing, do we give speculative and critical futures a foothold beside it, or leave India's live practice outside the machinery?
5. If India's procedural, plural idiom is a thing global AI tools cannot reproduce, do we codify and teach it now, before homogenisation, or leave the advantage uncoded and exportable?

Source Confidence Register

30 verified sources across four themes. Tier 1 (government, UN bodies, national statistics, primary institutional): 6. Tier 2 (universities, think-tanks, consultancies, industry bodies): 18. Tier 3 (quality journalism and specialist press): 6. No Tier 4 sources are load-bearing. Sources include Indian-market and government outlets alongside global bodies. This is a structural foresight topic, so some evidence is foundational (policies, studies and institutional reports): 14 sources are flagged structural anchors and 3 evergreen, used for structural context; the balance are 2026-dated. 24 of the 30 sources (80%) sit at Tier 1 or 2; the source set was frozen at 2026-07-21. Every dated source was verified against genuinely fetched page text. Detect → Assess → Decide → Act.

Theme 1: The Hollowed On-Ramp

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim
NITI Aayog (with BCG & NASSCOM)	T1	10 Oct 2025	78,000 tech employees had lost jobs to AI by mid-2025; ~60% of formal-sector jobs are automation-susceptible by 2030.
Rest of World	T3	9 Dec 2025	Indian IT services cut entry-level positions 20-25% to automation and AI, per EY; junior on-ramps are closing.
Figma / YouGov (via NewsBytes)	T3	13 Nov 2025	93% of Indian designers use AI tools, the highest adoption of any surveyed market.
Adobe	T2	28 Oct 2025	86% of global creators use creative generative AI, with India cited as a top-ROI AI adoption market.
ETS with CII, AICTE, AIU (India Skills Report 2026)	T2	11 Nov 2025	Graduate employability is 56.35%; over 90% of employees use generative AI; India holds 16% of the global AI talent pool.
Press Information Bureau, Government of India	T1	19 Dec 2025	Per Stanford's AI Index 2025, India leads the world in AI talent acquisition (~33% annual hiring rate), with AI talent concentration up threefold since 2016.
Economic Survey 2025-26 (via Business Today)	T2	29 Jan 2026	India's working-age (15-59) population surpasses 98 crore (~65%) by 2030, when the demographic dividend is projected to peak.

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim
ETV Bharat	T2	6 Jul 2026	India had the second-highest share of global tech layoffs (7.16%) as firms shifted from entry-level programming to specialised AI skills, leaving a ~50% AI talent shortfall.

Theme 2: Demand Without a Home

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim
India Design Council (DPIIT)	T2	8 Feb 2007	The National Design Policy of 2007 remains India's governing design framework; the India Design Council (2009) has had no 2025-26 relaunch.
Grand View Research	T2	17 Nov 2025	India's product design and development services market grows from US\$1.42bn (2024) to US\$2.71bn by 2030, the fastest in Asia-Pacific.
Oliver Wyman (with NASSCOM)	T2	12 Nov 2025	India GCCs are moving into R&D, product P&L and GenAI deployment as transformation hubs, doing global innovation and foresight work in-house.
ANSR (via GlobeNewswire)	T3	22 Dec 2025	610+ emerging-enterprise GCCs employ 462,000 professionals at \$14.23bn revenue, growing ~14% toward 1,200 centres by 2030.
Superflux	T3	17 Jun 2026	A leading experiential-futures and speculative-design studio with NID roots operates from London, illustrating diaspora-anchored Indian foresight capability.
Nasscom-Zinnov	T1	3 Jul 2026	India hosts 2,117 GCCs across 3,728 units employing ~2.36 million professionals and generating \$98.4 billion as of FY26, increasingly leading the AI mandate for global parents.
AlphaStreet India	T2	2 Feb 2026	The Union Budget 2026-27 proposes a new National Institute of Design in the eastern region,

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim
			citing a shortage of Indian designers and insufficient institutional capacity.

Theme 3: Two Non-Western Futures

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim
Social & Political Research Foundation	T2	29 Dec 2025	India's orange economy is being fused with Make in India: ~2.5m active creators, a \$1bn creator fund, M&E toward Rs 3.07 trillion by 2027.
EY / FICCI-EY	T2	24 Mar 2026	India's media and entertainment sector grew 9% to Rs 2.78 trillion in 2025, driven by digital and live experiences.
Observer Research Foundation	T2	4 Feb 2026	India's creative economy is ~US\$35bn with creative exports of ~US\$11bn in 2023, now a state-branded soft-power and export project.
Gahlot, Barnes, Suhendra & St John (Springer)	T2	13 Feb 2025	Indian design education stays Western-centric and even decolonisation over-centres design; jugaad is proposed as an autonomous curriculum model.
OCAD University (Pupul Bisht)	T2	1 Dec 2017	A non-Western foresight method adapting India's Kaavad folk-storytelling tradition, one of the only foresight methods drawn from a non-Western tradition.
Organiser	T3	4 Mar 2026	By March 2026, 16 Indian Knowledge Systems initiatives span premier institutions (IITs Kharagpur, Madras, Mandi; IIMs Nagpur, Sambalpur; Central Sanskrit University), turning the UGC mandate into a coordinated movement.
India Briefing (Dezan Shira)	T2	16 Feb 2026	India's media and entertainment sector is projected at Rs 2,873 billion (~\$31.8bn) in 2026, with live entertainment alone supporting over 10 million jobs.

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim
Dezeen	T2	19 Feb 2026	The 14th India Design ID (February 2026, New Delhi), themed 'The Age of Design Syncretism', gathered 150+ Indian brands with a symposium foregrounding plural, syncretic design futures.

Theme 4: The 2047 Foresight Machine

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim
NITI Aayog	T1	Apr 2026	India's dominant government foresight mode is long-horizon 2047 roadmap-writing (Viksit Bharat), aspirational target-setting rather than scenario practice.
Government of Telangana (via Barchart)	T2	6 Dec 2025	Telangana launched a Rising 2047 vision at a Bharat Future City summit, the first Indian state explicitly targeting global talent attraction.
Defence Research and Development Organisation	T1	17 Jul 2026	India runs institutional technology-foresight functions (DRDO, PSA/PM-STIAC) focused on tech horizon-scanning rather than plural or speculative futures.
UNESCO	T1	1 Jan 2012	UNESCO frames Futures Literacy as a learnable capability developed through Futures Literacy Laboratories since 2012, the discipline India lacks a home for.
Khoj International Artists' Association	T2	13 Dec 2025	Speculative courtroom hearings with real judges test how environmental loss might be represented as legal evidence, a procedural India futures idiom.
ArtAsiaPacific	T3	2 Mar 2026	The Kochi-Muziris Biennale 2025-26 hosts speculative climate courtrooms staged toward real future litigation, design-futures-as-jurisprudence.

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim
India TV News	T2	11 Jun 2026	At the 11th NITI Aayog Governing Council (June 2026), the Viksit Bharat 2047 roadmap set 100-day and five-year state targets under a monitoring framework, deepening foresight as target-setting.

Conflict notes: Three genuine tensions were weighted rather than resolved. (1) The on-ramp: NITI Aayog, EY and ETV Bharat warn of AI job displacement while the PIB and Stanford AI Index show India leading global AI-talent acquisition; the report treats the compression as real at the junior rung and a repositioning at the top. (2) The domestic home: the "no home" thesis versus the reading that GCCs, diaspora studios and the state 2047 machinery are the emerging homes; the report frames it as white space while carrying the reconfiguration counter, noting the Budget 2026-27 new-NID proposal cuts both ways. (3) Two non-Western futures: the state Bharatiya project versus the academic pluriversal one; the report frames them as a contest that policy design could reconcile. Coverage: the set is strong on government, UN and industry sources; the speculative-practice evidence rests on studios, biennales and India Design ID treated as directional; the Organiser IKS piece is a Bharatiya-aligned outlet, cited for the rollout it documents.

Claim-Fidelity Appendix: Analyst inferences and editorial framing

This briefing carries a set of analyst-generated interpretations that go beyond what any single source asserts. They are named here so a reader can trace the confidence line and disagree productively.

Analytical inferences carried by the body prose

- "Uneven ground" and "staffing the world's futures" are analyst frames linking the present demand, the capability gap and the export of talent into one pattern; no single source asserts the composite.
- Treating the absence of a home as a binding constraint rather than a temporary lag is our interpretation, and is contested by the GCC-and-state-as-emerging-home counter-argument carried in the body.
- Casting India's futures practice as "procedural, not object-based" and structurally invisible to Western-trained AI tools synthesises the Kochi, jugaad and Kaavad evidence into one thesis; the AI-blindness claim is ours, not a source's.
- Reading the Bharatiya and pluriversal projects as "two non-Western futures pulling the field apart" is an analyst reconciliation of the Indian Knowledge Systems and orange-economy evidence with the jugaad and decolonial scholarship.
- The analogy to India's IT-services ascent, staffing the world rather than owning the product, is an interpretive overlay chosen to discipline the thesis, not a claim the sources make.
- The absence of a university futures-studies centre and of a revised National Design Policy is reported as a "white space"; this is an inference from not finding them in the current evidence, and is flagged as a watch-item rather than a proven negative.

Editorial framing

The title "Trained Judgement, Uneven Ground" is an editorial compression that echoes the global cycle "Trained Judgement in the Age of Automated Foresight"; "uneven ground" names the mismatch between present demand and talent and the absent institutions, a direction of travel rather than a completed outcome. As the inaugural India edition, this report sets a baseline rather than grading a prior cycle. Because the topic moves slowly, the source base is heavily foundational, with many structural anchors and evergreen reference pages rather than last-quarter news, and that composition is disclosed in the Source Confidence Register.

The Futures Wheel and the in-body figure SVGs are analyst constructions built from the sourced claims; they carry no separate source-register entry, so a claim or quantification flag on those elements is expected and disclosed here rather than being a provenance failure.